Haveli Lane Library

Member Handbook, 2026 Edition

Welcome

Haveli Lane Library was founded in 1931 by the schoolteacher Sushila Devi Rastogi, who began it with 212 books lent from the front room of her home. Today the library holds about 48,000 books and serves the old quarter of the town from a restored three-storey haveli. This handbook explains how membership works, what you may borrow, and how to look after the collection.

Opening hours

The library is open from Tuesday to Sunday, 9:30 am to 7:00 pm. It is closed every Monday and on national holidays. The Children's Corner on the ground floor closes earlier, at 5:30 pm. During the monsoon months of July and August the top-floor reading terrace stays closed.

Membership

There are three kinds of membership. A student membership costs Rs 150 per year and needs a valid student identity card. A regular adult membership costs Rs 400 per year. A family membership costs Rs 900 per year and covers up to four people living at one address.

To join, bring one photograph and proof of your address to the front desk. Your membership card is printed on the same day. A replacement for a lost card costs Rs 50. Memberships run for twelve months from the date of joining and can be renewed up to thirty days before they end.

Volunteers

The library depends on volunteers. Members who give at least ten hours a month receive a free renewal of their membership. Volunteers help with shelving, the Saturday story hour and the repair of damaged books. Ask for the volunteer coordinator, Mr Imran Qureshi, at the front desk.

Borrowing books

A member may borrow up to 4 books at one time. The loan period is 21 days. A loan can be renewed twice, once at a time, for a further 14 days each, unless another member has reserved the book. Renew at the front desk or by telephone. Reference books, newspapers and anything marked with a red dot cannot be taken out of the building.

Fines

The fine for returning a book late is Rs 2 per day for each book. Children's books have a lower fine of Re 1 per day. Fines stop at Rs 200 for any one book. Members who owe more than Rs 100 cannot borrow again until the amount is paid. A lost or badly damaged book must be replaced, or paid for at twice its listed price.

Reservations

If a book is out on loan you may reserve it at the front desk for a fee of Rs 5. You will get a text message when it comes back, and the book will be held for you for 3 days. Each member may hold up to 2 reservations at a time.

The Rare Books Room

The Rare Books Room on the second floor holds manuscripts and first editions, including the Rastogi Collection of Hindi periodicals from the 1920s. It is open only on Saturdays, from 11:00 am to 2:00 pm. To enter you must show your membership card and leave a refundable deposit of Rs 500 at the desk. Only pencils may be used in the room, and cotton gloves are provided. Nothing from this room may be borrowed or photographed with a flash.

Facilities

The main reading hall seats 60 people and has a quiet zone at its eastern end. Photocopying is available at the front desk at Rs 2 per page. Free Wi-Fi is available to members, and the password changes on the first day of each month. Lockers on the ground floor can be used during your visit for a refundable Rs 10 coin. A small tea stall run by Mrs Lata Joshi operates in the courtyard from 10:00 am to 5:00 pm. Food and drink are not allowed past the courtyard.

Events

A story hour for children aged 5 to 10 takes place every Saturday at 4:00 pm in the Children's Corner. The Haveli Readers' Circle meets on the last Sunday of each month at 5:00 pm to discuss one book chosen by vote. Each year in the second week of November the library holds its Old Book Fair in the courtyard, when withdrawn books are sold at Rs 20 each.

Behaviour and care of books

Please keep your voice low in the reading hall and keep your telephone on silent. Do not write in books, fold their pages or use them as trays. If you find a damaged book, hand it to the staff without trying to repair it. The repair team meets on Thursday mornings and uses only acid-free paper and wheat paste.

Contact

Haveli Lane Library, 17 Haveli Lane, Old Quarter. Telephone: 0522-4471930. Email: desk@havelilane.example. The chief librarian is Dr Meera Saxena, who keeps open office hours on Wednesdays from 3:00 pm to 5:00 pm.